

# Introductions



DAEN 640 Capstone Senior Design

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Jan 2026

# Plan for today

**Introductions**

**Goals & Expectations**

**Semester Overview**

**Grading & Assessment**

**Code of Conduct**

# Instructors

**Alexander  
Abuabara**



**Jose  
Vazquez**



**Jon  
Elizondo**





# Goals and Expectations

# What is The Most Important Thing?

*In life, the most important thing is subjective*

**Health, Love & Relationships, Purpose & Meaning,  
Gratitude, Freedom, Learning & Growth, Self-Care**

These dimensions makes a conceptual backbone for our capstone,  
framing it not as a purely **technical** culmination experience,  
but as a **professional & personal transition course**

# The Bridge Between Academic Training & Life (After Graduation)

Comprehensive **technical expertise!**

Learn to **go beyond** working your team's project,  
develop the ability to work in any project!

Success is fully achieved when combined with  
**strong communication!**





**Capstone Design represents the culmination of an educational journey**

**It's where **theory** meets **practice**, **abstraction** meets **reality****

**The individual student transitions from learning concepts to creating, evaluating, and owning a complete system**



# Goals

**Apply data engineering knowledge**

**Develop end-to-end project skills**

**Plan, document, execute projects using a structured framework (V-Model)**

**Foster collaboration & professional skills**

**Build a portfolio demonstrating technical & teamwork skills**

**Prepare for industry & research**

**Strengthen problem-solving & critical thinking**

**Experience working under professional expectations**



# Expectations

**Active Participation**

**Ownership & Accountability**

**Professional Communication**

**Quality & Documentation**

**Ethical Conduct**

# ISEN Mission Statement

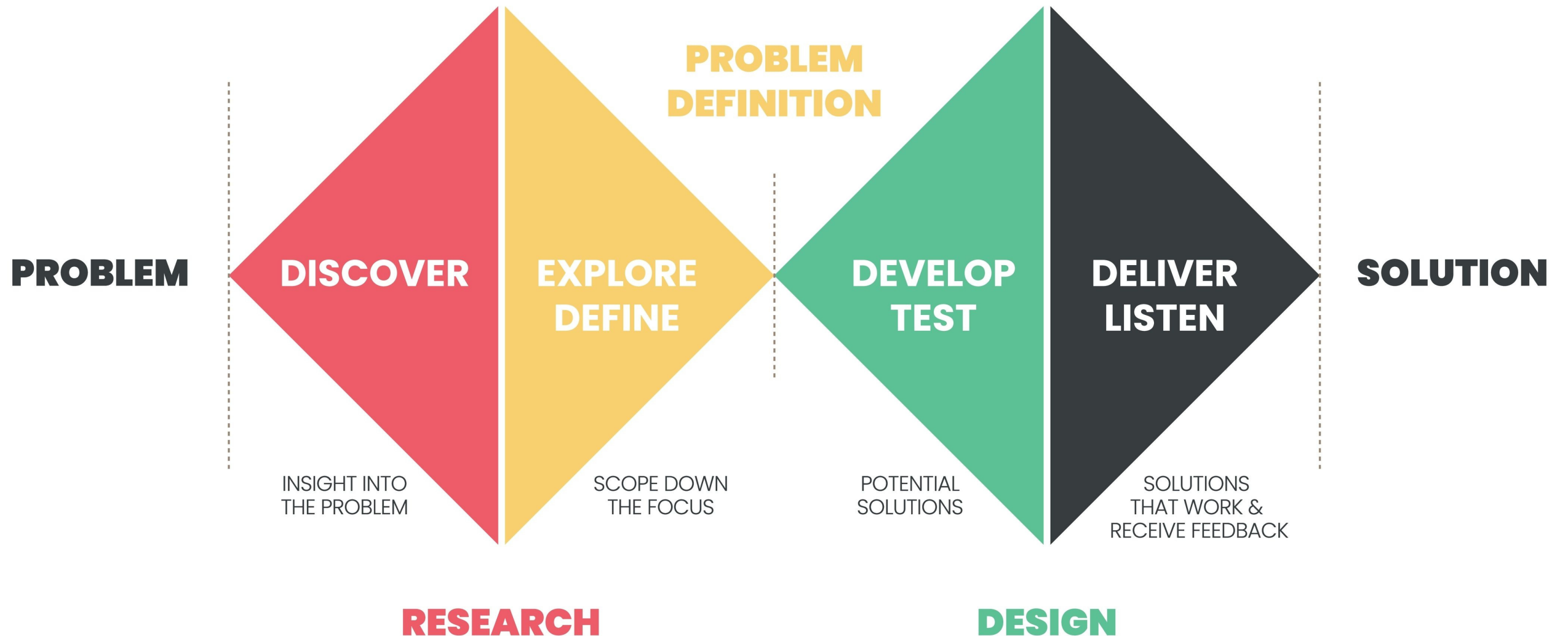
**To serve** the state, nation and global community by educating industrial engineering students to be well founded in engineering fundamentals and **to have the knowledge and skills** required **to design, develop, improve, implement and control** sophisticated production and service **systems** in an environment characterized by **complex technical and social challenges** . Throughout this educational process, students will be instilled with the **highest standards of professional and ethical behavior**.



**INDUSTRIAL & SYSTEMS  
ENGINEERING**  
TEXAS A&M UNIVERSITY

# Semester Overview

# DESIGN THINKING PROCESS



# Discover: Understand the Problem

**Purpose: Explore and learn before building**

- Investigate the problem domain
- Identify stakeholders and users
- Study existing solutions and technologies
- Gather data (surveys, literature, benchmarks)
- Uncover unmet needs and constraints

**Outcome: Clear understanding of what problem matters and why**

# Define: Frame the Right Problem

**Purpose: Turn research into a focused project**

- Synthesize findings into insights
- Write a precise problem statement
- Define scope, objectives, and constraints
- Establish functional and performance requirements
- Set success metrics and milestones

**Outcome: A well-scoped, testable project definition**

# Develop: Design and Build

**Purpose: Create and validate the solution**

- Generate and compare design concepts
- Select the optimal solution
- Create system architecture and models
- Build prototypes or minimum viable products
- Test, iterate, and refine based on data

**Outcome: A functional, validated engineering solution**

# Deliver: Validate and Communicate

**Purpose: Prepare for real-world use and evaluation**

- Perform final verification and validation
- Confirm performance meets requirements
- Finalize documentation, code, and design artifacts
- Prepare reports, posters, and presentations
- Demonstrate the solution to stakeholders

**Outcome: A complete, defensible project ready for deployment and assessment**



# Weekly Schedule

| Week | Date | Topic                                                       |
|------|------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | 1/13 | Introductions + Comm Requirements                           |
| 2    | 1/20 | Integrate Engineering Design ( <i>The Toaster Project</i> ) |



# Weekly Schedule

| Week | Date | Topic                                   |
|------|------|-----------------------------------------|
| 3    | 1/27 | Phase 1 Kickoff                         |
| 4    | 2/3  | Phase 1 Presentations - Groups BH & COE |
| 5    | 2/10 | Phase 1 Presentations - Groups ML       |
|      |      |                                         |
| 6    | 2/17 | Phase 2 Kickoff                         |
| 7    | 2/24 | Phase 2 Presentations - Groups BH & COE |
| 8    | 3/3  | Phase 2 Presentations - Groups ML       |

March 7-15



# Weekly Schedule

| Week | Date | Topic                                   |
|------|------|-----------------------------------------|
| 9    | 3/17 | Phase 3 Kickoff                         |
| 10   | 3/24 | Phase 3 Presentations - Groups BH & COE |
| 11   | 3/31 | Phase 3 Presentations - Groups ML       |
|      |      |                                         |
| 12   | 4/7  | Phase 4 Kickoff                         |
| 13   | 4/14 | Phase 4 Presentations - Groups BH & COE |
| 14   | 4/21 | Phase 4 Presentations - Groups ML       |

# Attendance

- Mandatory attendance for everyone:
  - First two weeks of class
  - Phase kick-offs
- Team presentation days:
  - All team members must stay for the entire class!
  - Other students are welcome & encouraged to attend

# Again

## Phase Kickoff Weeks

- Entire team **must be present**
- Details on phase
  - Content
  - Deliverables (checklist)
- Communications Activities
- Project guidance/tips

# And Again

## Presentation Weeks

- On the day for your group, **entire team must be present, the entire time!**
- Appropriate attire
- Be a good listener
- **Ask** questions, participate!
- You are welcomed/**encouraged** to attend presentations on the day of the other group

# Faculty Advisor

**Each team must select a Texas A&M faculty advisor.**

- Advisors are chosen for their expertise or interest in the project topic.
- Instructors may assist in identifying advisors if needed.



# Faculty Advisor

- Advisors serve as the team's subject matter expert, providing guidance & recommendations.
- Biweekly meetings are recommended, based on advisor availability.
- Advisors take an active advisory role but are not responsible for developing solutions.
- Teams must treat advisors with professional respect & courtesy.

# Sponsors

- The project sponsor is the **client**, owner of the project problem or opportunity.
- Each team must assign a *Point of Contact* to manage sponsor communication.
- Communication frequency & format should be defined based on sponsor availability.
- Regular **face-to-face** meetings (in person or video) are required; email alone is insufficient!

# Sponsors

**ALL team members** should attend sponsor meetings;  
absences must be acknowledged with reasons

- Meetings are scheduled by the POC and sponsor and must start and end on time with an agenda.
- Only the sponsor may cancel meetings; cancellations must be reported in technical presentations.
- If meeting frequency is unacceptable to the sponsor, document it and consult the primary instructor.

# Confidentiality & Non-attribution

- Course data, client info, and project discussions are confidential
  - Share information only with classmates or instructors, following confidentiality rules
- Keep confidential materials secure
  - In a folder, binder, or password-protected device
  - On your person or in a safe location (room, backpack, car)

# Confidentiality & Non-attribution

- Don't attribute information to specific people or teams
  - Use phrases like: "It's my understanding that..."
- Treat NDAs seriously!



# Grading & Assessment

| Team Grades             | Weight on the Final Grade | Grade Type    |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|---------------|
| Mini Management Packet  | 5%                        | Technical     |
| Phase 1-3 Presentations | 15% (5% each)             | "             |
| Phase 4 Presentation    | 10%                       | "             |
| Showcase Poster         | 5%                        | "             |
| Communication Log       | 2% (1% each)              | "             |
| Final Report            | 18%                       | "             |
|                         |                           |               |
| Individual Grades       |                           |               |
| Phase Presentations     | 15%                       | Communication |
| Writing Assignments     | 18%                       | Writing       |
| Peer Performance        | 12%                       |               |

# Deliverables

- Code of Conduct: will not be graded but must be turned in as a group assignment!
- As well other things in the deliverables table: Showcase Registration, Meeting Logs, etc.



# Deliverables

- Check Canvas for all official due dates
  - They're final unless we send a notice by Canvas + email
- You can resubmit assignments for a better grade after the due date
- All regrade work must be in by the assignment's close date
- When resubmitting, make sure to:
  - Highlight what you changed
  - Address ALL feedback from class, presentations, or office hours

# Use AI responsibly and within limits

- Brainstorm ideas
- Check your work for grammar, spelling, clarity, and brevity

**AI = tool, not shortcut!**

**AI should support learning, not replace it!  
Always ask questions and participate in class**

**Use AI in ways you could confidently explain to your instructor or classmates.**

# You may NOT use AI to

- Write assignments for you
- Solve major problems or programming tasks
- Generate analyses or substantive content

**All work must reflect your own effort  
Misuse may be treated as academic dishonesty!**

**Do NOT input confidential sponsor information into AI tools**

# Team Work



In industry, project failure is rarely caused by lack of technical skill.

Most often caused by:

Unclear expectations

Poor communication

Uneven workload distribution

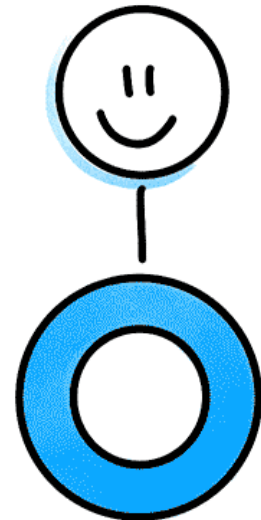
Missed deadlines

Unresolved conflict

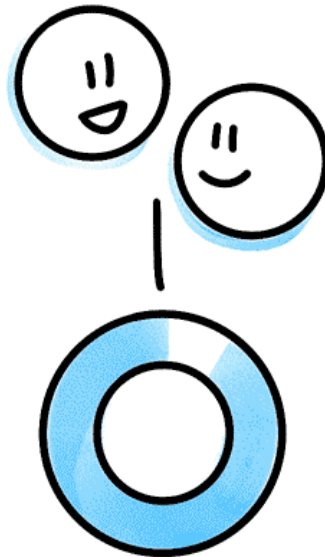
Unprofessional behavior

# WHAT IS **SOCIAL LOAFING?**

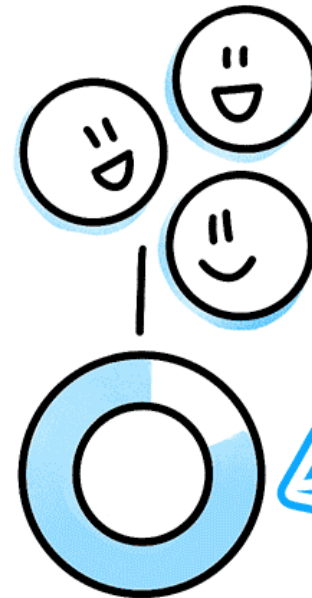
How does  
it impact teams?



100%  
EFFORT



93%  
EFFORT EACH



85%  
EFFORT EACH

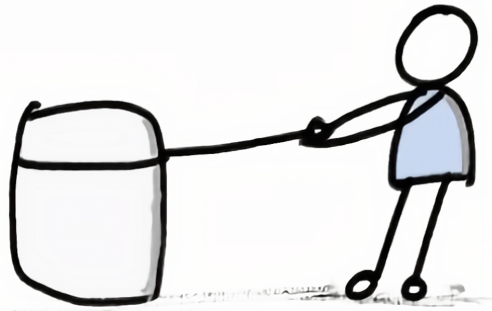
Psychological  
Phenomenon  
that people do  
less work when  
they're in a  
group setting.

# Examples of social loafing

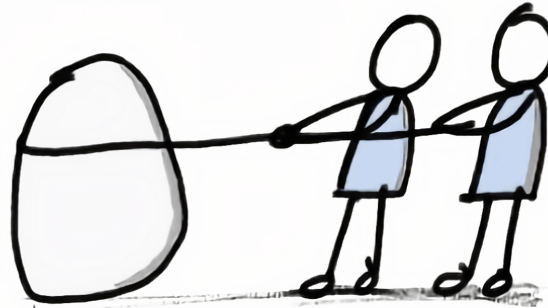
- Disappearing after class and not responding to messages.
- Continuing poor communication even after being made aware of the issue.
- Expecting the team to adjust around your personal schedule.
- Missing meetings, arriving late, or leaving early on a regular basis.
- Failing to complete assigned work, or turning in work that is incomplete, careless, or must be redone by teammates.
- Working on off-topic ideas without team approval and expecting credit.
- Attending meetings but being distracted (by phone instead of participating).

**All team members MUST be reliable, communicative, prepared, and engaged!**

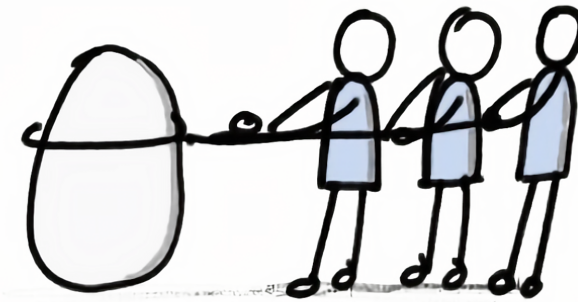
# Social Loafing means not contributing your fair share to team work



100% effort



93% effort each



85% effort each

**This behavior creates serious problems for teams  
and is taken very seriously in this course**

# Code of Conduct



# Code of Conduct

**Let us prevent these problems BEFORE they occur**

On Canvas - Due 1/19 at 5 PM

<https://canvas.tamu.edu/courses/431435/assignments/2874310>



# Professional Standards of Conduct

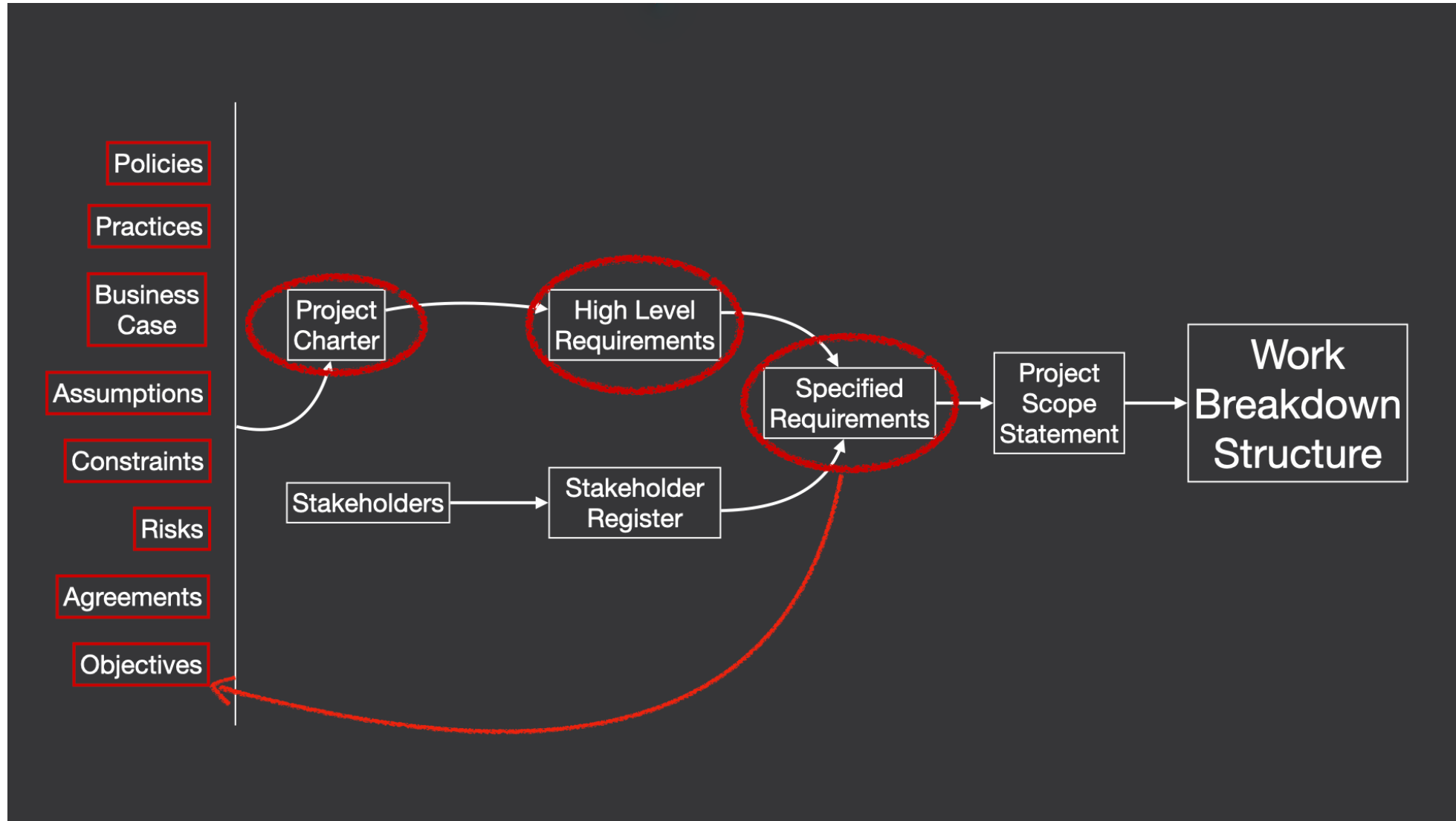
- Learning includes respectfully engaging with different opinions & keeping an open mind.
- All in this course is expected to treat others with **courtesy, respect, and professionalism.**
- These expectations apply to **all** course-related activities & meetings.
- Communication should be factual, constructive, and free of harassing, offensive, or demeaning language.

# Professional Standards of Conduct

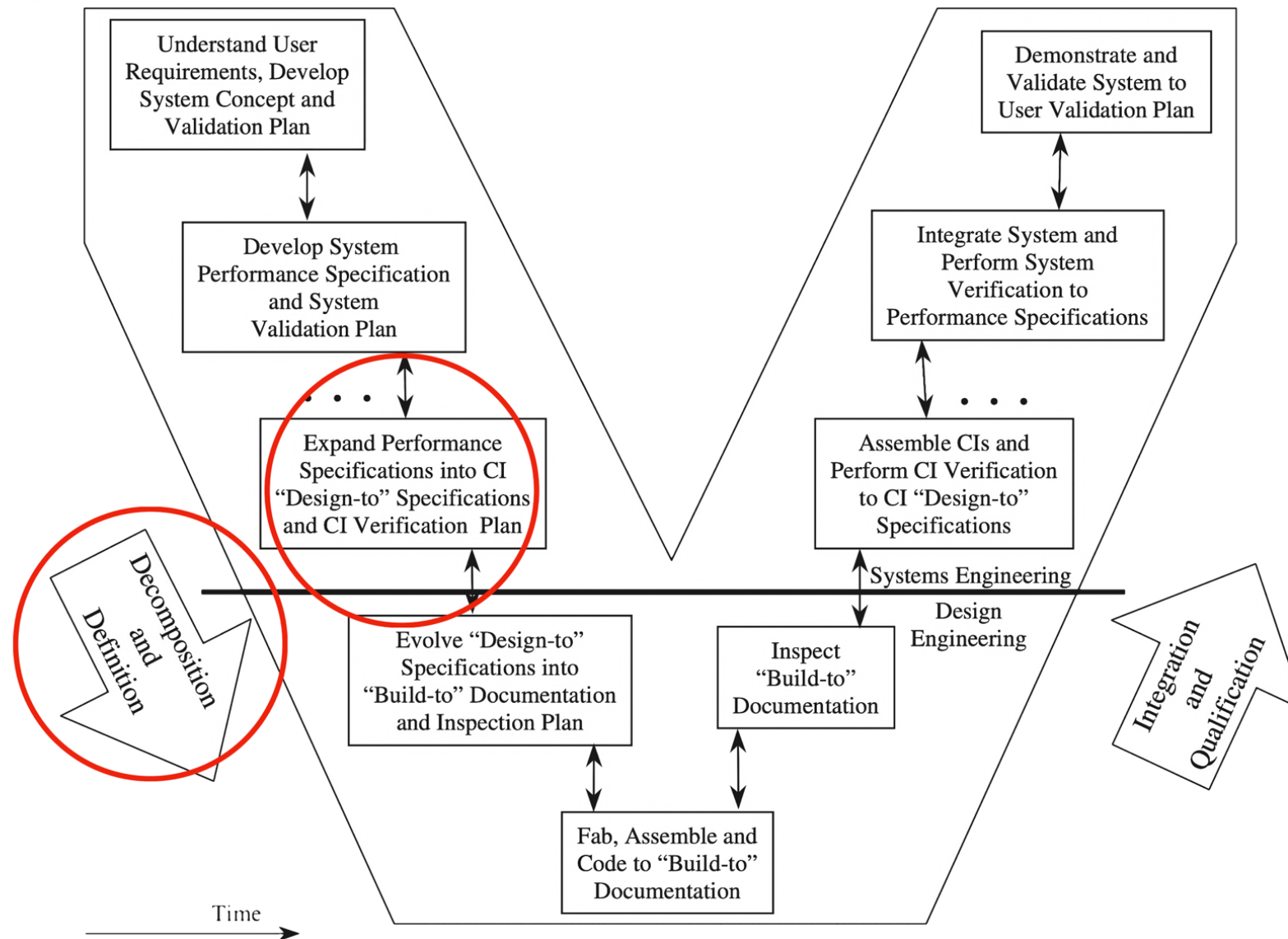
- Disagreements are allowed,  
... but they must be fact-based & civil in tone.
- Abusive, disruptive, threatening, harassing behavior and profanity are **NOT** acceptable.
- If an issue occurs, individuals will usually be informed and guided on appropriate behavior, and are expected to correct it.
- Serious violations may result in University disciplinary action.
- Students are responsible for knowing and following all student rules and policies.

# Next Week Preview

# Project Charter Adjustments



# V-Model



**What is a Configuration Item?**

**What is a Configuration Item  
in Data Engineering?**

# What is a Configuration Item (CI)?

Any hardware, software, firmware, document, or combination thereof that is:

**Individually identifiable**

**Formally baselined**

**Controlled under configuration management**

**Verified against approved specifications**

In other words, a CI is anything the organization has decided must be controlled, versioned, and verified as its own official product element.



# What Counts as a CI in a Data Platform

- In data engineering, a CI is:
  - Any version-controlled, independently testable, production-quality component of a data system that has formal requirements, formal tests, and formal approval.
- A CI is no longer "just a file", it becomes a certified system component.

| CI Area       | Examples                    |
|---------------|-----------------------------|
| Sources       | Ingest schema, API feed     |
| Pipelines     | ETL job, stream proc        |
| Storage       | Warehouse schema, lakehouse |
| Code          | Feature lib, validation     |
| Models        | Forecast, classifier        |
| Orchestration | Airflow DAG, dbt            |
| Interfaces    | API, data contracts         |
| Governance    | Quality rules, PII mask     |
| Docs          | Data dict, lineage          |

"Hidden in Thomas Thwaites's deceptively simple story is an epic tale that touches on electronics, metallurgy, sustainability, social history, consumerism, epistemology, and global post-industrial capitalism, among other things. It's also funny as hell. Dare I say it? *The Toaster Project* is the twenty-first century's first masterpiece of design writing." —MICHAEL BIERUT, *Pentagram*

"*The Toaster Project* is so cool it is beyond words. It is art and science, history and the future, all in one brilliant idea. Although a tiny project, it is mythic in scope. Once seen, never forgotten." —KEVIN KELLY, *Wired*

"Hello, my name is Thomas Thwaites, and I have made a toaster."

So begins *The Toaster Project*, the author's nine-month-long journey from his local appliance store to remote mines in the UK to his mother's backyard, where he creates a crude foundry. Along the way, he learns that an ordinary toaster is made up of 404 separate parts, that the best way to smelt metal at home is by using a method found in a sixteenth-century treatise, and that plastic is almost impossible to make from scratch. In the end, Thwaites's homemade toaster—a haunting and strangely beautiful object—cost 250 times more than the toaster he bought at the store and involved close to two thousand miles of travel to some of Britain's most isolated locations.

*The Toaster Project* may seem foolish, even insane. Yet, Thwaites's quixotic tale, told with self-deprecating wit, helps us reflect on the costs and perils of our cheap consumer culture, and in so doing reveals much about the organization of the modern world and our place in it.

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Princeton Architectural Press  
[www.papress.com](http://www.papress.com)



## The Toaster Project

Thomas Thwaites

# The Toaster Project

OR A HEROIC ATTEMPT TO  
BUILD A SIMPLE ELECTRIC APPLIANCE  
FROM SCRATCH



Thomas Thwaites

"Just get married, people give them to you. It's much easier." —Stephen Colbert

Check out ...

<https://www.thomasthwaites.com/the-toaster-project/>



**Make it a GREAT semester! ツ**

